



sofas, and tables last a long time. Well, they do if they're built well anyway. I scour Craigslist.org when I'm looking for furniture. You can often find a solid oak desk with great craftsmanship for a lot cheaper than you can get one of those nasty MDF things that you put together yourself. Sure, you'll need a way to get it home. If you don't have a big truck, just rent one from U-Haul for a few hours for \$20. You'll end up with a great piece of furniture you can hand down to your grandchildren, rather than something that ends up in the garbage after two years.

Sports gear

Footballs, tennis rackets, bicycles, soccer balls, badminton nets—you name it, you can find it all used.

They're usually in excellent shape and a whole lot cheaper than store prices.

Houses

There's a huge caveat on this one: Make sure it's been checked out by an inspector and has the green light. You don't want to take on major plumbing problems, damp basements, or termites. But, if the house is sound, a hurting economy makes a used home very, very desirable. Sometimes it's just a few years old; there are homes in my area that have decreased in value by \$70K in just a few years during down times. Ouch. But not for you. Of course, the used-home sales market is also affecting new home sales. If you insist on buying new, make sure you battle hard with the realtor and look for inventory houses. They just want them sold, so you can often negotiate serious discounts and tons of free upgrades.

Plants

I do not have green fingers. No one in my family does. So, I like to let someone else do the hard work of establishing a plant and giving it healthy roots. Then I'll pick one up cheap at a garage sale or off Craigslist.org.